

RAKESH ARORA (name changed) was pursuing engineering from a small regional college in Kanpur, Uttar Pradesh, when he had to think about his next big move in life. With his brother encouraging him to pursue his interests, Arora found a side gig: teaching students preparing for competitive examinations at a nearby coaching centre that paid ₹5,000 a month. Arora's headline moment came when one of his students aced the coveted JEE Mains (Joint Entrance Examination for admission to the Indian Institutes of Technology) and got accepted into IIT Delhi, one of India's premier engineering colleges. "*Har koi chahta hai ki humara padaya hua bachha IIT jaye* (Every teacher wants his student to get into an IIT)," he says.

Following this success, Arora realised that teaching was his true calling. He skipped his college placement process and instead joined a school. Now, he was earning ₹15,000 a month. The happiness that came with being a teacher was sadly not enough to cover the costs of living. Arora started working for Aakash Institute (which was later acquired by edtech decacorn BYJU'S) at a monthly salary of ₹42,000. A few years later, he left Aakash to launch his own coaching centre.

But then came the Covid-19 pandemic. His coaching centre shut down before it could properly take off. Arora admits that managing his day-to-day expenses was an uphill battle. Worse, he was threatened with eviction if he didn't pay his house's EMIs. That is when he started looking for alternative sources of income. Little did he know that the pot of gold lay just around the corner.

'Arora sir', as he is fondly called by his students, began creating and uploading instructional videos on YouTube. Initially, his videos were only viewed by those who already knew him, but eventually, they gained popularity among students throughout the country, particularly among those who were preparing for competitive exams. "From Aurangabad to Nagpur, students started writing to me about how my teaching pattern resonated with them. In the comments section, I would ask them which chapter they wanted to study next. They also gave me feedback on my videos."

During the day, he would record the sessions, and then later that night, he and his brother would edit the footage and upload them to the video-streaming service. The next day, he would start filming videos for the next chapter. This routine went on for two to three months before the next breakthrough. Arora's videos went from having 100 views in a week to 4,000-5,000

views each day. The bigwigs in his field took notice of his 140,000 Instagram followers. In November 2021, he was called by one of India's leading edtech unicorns, which offered him a lucrative salary to join its team. Arora says he now makes ₹1.5 crore annually.

And, his life has changed since he joined the edtech start-up. Now, paying his EMIs is a breeze and he intends to finish them off earlier than anticipated. He was also able to purchase a car for the first time ever: an MG Hector. His kids attend a 'big school' in Delhi, and he and his family can take frequent vacations to upscale locations. "*Ab itna milta hai ki ab zindagi maze se nikal jayegi* (Now I make enough to live comfortably)," Arora tells BT.

Not just Arora, many teachers in India are earning in crores now. This situation was unthinkable just a few years ago. But, what brought this change?

The Tech- tonic Shift

Teachers in our country have historically been held in high regard. But they were usually paid low salaries. Even today, according to interviews conducted by BT with a small sample of educational institutions, the median annual salary of teachers in secondary schools range from ₹3.5-5 lakh for freshers and ₹5-15 lakh for those with more than 10 years of experience. Those at the higher secondary level can expect to earn ₹1-1.5 lakh a month. Besides low salaries, they also deal with difficulties like lack of benefits and job security. As many as 42 per cent of the teachers in India work without a contract, per Unesco's State of the Education Report for India in 2020; and they earn an average monthly salary of less than ₹10,000.



India's edtech market will grow to \$4 billion by 2025 from \$750 million in 2020, according to IBEF estimates